Chart chooser

Pick the chart from the question, not from habit · McKesson data-viz guide

1. Write the question the chart answers → 2. Find its type below and start with the first choice → 3. Run the sanity checks at the bottom → 4. Follow the cookbook page for the build

Magnitude

cookbook/bar.md

How big? Which is bigger, and by how much?



Sorted bar / column

ALSO Dot plot (values far from zero), proportional bubbles (huge ranges)

CARE Pictograms

e.g. Attrition by job family; open reqs by site

Part-to-whole

cookbook/stacked-bar.md

What is it made of? How does a total break down?



100% stacked bar

ALSO Waterfall (bridge between totals), treemap (hierarchies, many parts)

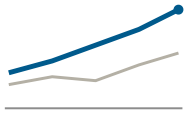
CARE Donut / pie: 5 parts max, one whole

e.g. Workforce mix; FY25 → FY26 labor cost bridge

Change over time

cookbook/line.md

How is it moving? When did it change?



Line, focus series in blue

ALSO Columns (few periods), stacked area (composition + total), small multiples

CARE Bubble timeline (events)

e.g. Monthly attrition; SWP demand vs. supply

Ranking

cookbook/slope-bump.md

Who's on top? Who moved?



Sorted bar; slope for change in rank

ALSO Bump chart (rank over 3+ periods)

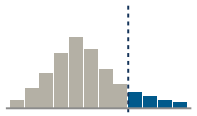
CARE Heat table (see tables.md)

e.g. Top skills in postings, 2023 → 2026

Distribution

cookbook/distribution.md

How spread out? What's typical? Where are the outliers?



Histogram, strip or box plot

ALSO Dot plot of medians

CARE An average with no spread

e.g. Compa-ratio within band; span of control; tenure

Correlation

cookbook/scatter-bubble.md

Do two measures move together?



Scatter / bubble scatter

ALSO Heatmap (two categories × one measure)

CARE Dual axis: use two aligned charts

e.g. Engagement vs. attrition by team; gen-AI exposure vs. pay

Relationships & flows

cookbook/sankey.md

How do things connect, or move between states?



Sankey (flows between states)

ALSO Parallel coordinates (multi-measure profiles)

CARE Venn: 3 sets max

e.g. Internal mobility between job families

Geo-spatial

cookbook/maps.md

Where?



Choropleth (rates by area)

ALSO Bubble map (counts at locations)

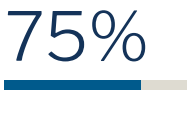
CARE Dot density

e.g. Talent availability by metro; headcount by DC

Single number

cookbook/kpi-big-number.md

What is the one figure to remember?



KPI / big number

ALSO Progress bar or ring for % of a target

CARE Speedometers, 3D gauges

e.g. 75% of critical roles have a ready successor

More than ~12 categories?
Sort horizontal bars by value, or group the tail into "Other".

Values clustered far from zero?
Don't truncate bars: use a dot plot or show the gap to benchmark.

Two units over time?
No dual axes: use two aligned charts, or index both to 100.

Many groups, same measure?
Small multiples on a shared scale, focus group highlighted in each.

Pie with 8 slices?
Use a sorted bar. Pies and donuts take 5 parts at most.